

TAGAR

Tabernaemontana divaricata (formerly *Ervatamia coronaria*)

Quick Facts

Scientific Name	Tabernaemontana divaricata (formerly Ervatamia coronaria)
Family	Apocynaceae (Dogbane family)
Common Names	Tagar (Bengali), Chandni (Hindi), Crepe Jasmine, Pinwheel Flower, East India Rosebay, Nero's Crown, Adam's Apple, Nandiar Vattai (Tamil), Nandyarvattom (Malayalam), Tagar (Sanskrit)
Native Origin	India, Bangladesh, Myanmar, and possibly southern China; widely cultivated across tropical Asia
Colors	Pure white. The single-flowered form has 5 pure white propeller-like twisted petals. A double-flowered cultivar (Tabernaemontana divaricata 'Flore Pleno') exists with multiple whorls of white petals resembling a small gardenia or rose.
Height	1 to 2.5 metres as a shrub. Occasionally reaches small tree size of 3 to 4 metres in mature specimens.
Blooming Season	Year-round throughout tropical India. Peak flowering occurs during March to November. In West Bengal, the plant blooms most profusely from March through October, coinciding with the warm humid season. Even in relatively dry winters, some flowering continues.

Distribution in India

Extremely common throughout India, particularly in West Bengal, Odisha, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, and Maharashtra. In West Bengal, it is one of the most common flowering shrubs in both urban and rural areas. Grown in home gardens, temple surroundings, parks, and roadside plantings. Particularly common in the Gangetic plains and coastal South India.

Description and Overview

Tabernaemontana divaricata, known as Tagar in Bengali and Chandni (moonlight) in Hindi, is one of the most familiar and culturally important flowering shrubs of the Indian subcontinent. The plant is a member of the Apocynaceae family and is closely related to the Giant Calotrope and Nayantara. Like them, it produces a milky latex when cut and contains alkaloids that give it medicinal significance.

The flowers of Tagar are distinctively beautiful. Each flower has five pure white petals arranged in a pinwheel or propeller-like pattern, with each petal slightly offset to give a spinning appearance. This distinctive arrangement gives the plant its English name Pinwheel Flower. The flowers are sweetly fragrant, particularly in the evening and at night, with a scent often described as similar to that of jasmine. They are produced in clusters at the branch tips and the plant flowers continuously through the

warm season.

The double-flowered variety (called Chandni in most of North India) has multiple layers of white petals and resembles a small gardenia. This cultivar is particularly popular in gardens and is the most commonly sold form in Indian nurseries. Both single and double forms are used in religious contexts.

In Hindu religious practice, Tagar flowers are widely used for worship and are one of the flowers recommended for offering to Shiva, Vishnu, and other deities across different regional traditions. In West Bengal, Tagar flowers are particularly associated with the worship of Shiva and are commonly strung into small garlands or offered loose. The plant is common in the grounds of temples and around cremation sites.

The plant's Sanskrit name 'Tagar' has ancient roots and appears in Ayurvedic texts. In Sanskrit literature, Tagar is also the name given to the root of *Valeriana wallichii* (Himalayan Valerian), which causes confusion in some older references. The plant *Tabernaemontana divaricata* is the botanical Tagar of the Bengali and Odia traditions.

Tabernaemontana divaricata is classified within the Apocynaceae family and contains numerous alkaloids in its bark, leaves, and latex, including voacangine, tabersonine, and coronaridine. These compounds have been studied for potential pharmacological properties including anti-cancer, anti-malarial, and analgesic effects.

Blooming Season and Conditions

Year-round throughout tropical India. Peak flowering occurs during March to November. In West Bengal, the plant blooms most profusely from March through October, coinciding with the warm humid season. Even in relatively dry winters, some flowering continues.

Cultivation

Tagar is one of the easiest ornamental shrubs to grow in India. It is propagated by stem cuttings taken from semi-hardwood growth. Cuttings of 15 to 20 cm root readily in sand or cocopeat, especially during the warm monsoon months of June to August. The plant establishes quickly and requires minimal care.

It grows in a wide range of soils from sandy to clay, and tolerates light shade as well as full sun, making it suitable for planting under partial tree cover. Pruning after the winter season promotes fresh bushy growth and abundant flowering. The plant is relatively pest-free in Indian conditions, though mealybug infestations can occur on nursery plants. It does not tolerate prolonged waterlogging but otherwise requires little attention once established.

Uses and Applications

Religious: Among the most widely used flowers in Hindu worship across eastern and southern India. Offered to Shiva, Vishnu, Lakshmi, and other deities. Used in garlands for festivals and puja.

Ornamental: A popular hedging and border plant in Indian gardens, frequently used to create informal fragrant hedges.

Traditional medicine: Root bark extracts are used in Ayurveda and folk medicine for treating inflammation, fever, eye disorders, and skin diseases. The plant contains alkaloids that inhibit certain cancer cell lines in laboratory studies.

Fragrance: The evening fragrance of the flowers makes them suitable for planting near windows, verandahs, and relaxation areas. Fragrant oil from the flowers is used in traditional perfumery.

Landscaping: Due to its year-round foliage, manageable size, and continuous flowering, it is a standard choice for low maintenance landscape planting in Indian institutional and public spaces.

Interesting Facts

- The species name 'divaricata' means 'spreading widely' in Latin, referring to the spreading branching habit of the plant.
- In West Bengal, Tagar has a strong association with Bengali cultural identity and appears in folk songs, literature, and as a symbol of simple, enduring beauty.
- The double-flowered Chandni variety is sterile and does not produce fruit — it is maintained entirely by vegetative (cutting) propagation.
- *Tabernaemontana* species are distributed across tropical Africa, Asia, and the Americas and are a rich source of monoterpene indole alkaloids that pharmaceutical researchers continue to study.
- The genus *Tabernaemontana* is named after Jacob Theodor von Bergzabern, a 16th-century German botanist whose Latin name was *Tabernaemontanus*.

Source: Flower AI Knowledge Base — TAGAR entry. Scientific name: *Tabernaemontana divaricata* (formerly *Ervatamia coronaria*). Family: Apocynaceae (Dogbane family).